paintings of the time, he has a slight frame, and a round face; at thirteen, the vestiges of childhood clung to him still. The paintings do not show that he was distraught.

For Abul Fazl, Humayun couldn't die soon enough. Finally, after so many reams spent setting the scene, the historian could get to the good bits, 'as the moment of time arrived which the heavens had been expecting for so many cycles'. Not so for Akbar. When news of his father's death arrived, he cried, and no one could console him, though many tried.[8] Akbar's mother, Hamida, was far away in Kabul – still unaware that she was widowed – but he had another mama by his side, Maham Anaka. He had a father figure, too, in Shamsuddin Ataka – husband of Maham's rival Jiji Anaka, the man who had helped Humayun escape the rout in Kannauj and watched over Akbar through the many years he spent hostage to his uncles. And there was, of course, Bairam Khan, Akbar's 'Khan Baba' and now his regent, taking pride of place by Akbar's side, and so too in the history of his young, heartbroken king's rise.

Besides these three, the most intimate of Akbar's early counsellors and guides, there were many other men, and a few women, who would play crucial roles in the early years of Akbar's reign. His coronation, for example, might have been a much more fraught affair if it hadn't been for the tight-fisted Tardi Beg, who took charge of Delhi when Humayun broke his crown. Over the next few days, Tardi Beg took several critical decisions: he appointed a lookalike to appear in public as Humayun so the city wouldn't panic and rival claimants wouldn't storm its gates; and he sent Akbar the insignia of rule, with declarations of his loyalty – and Mirza Abul Qasim.

This young prince is a shadowy character in the history of this time, and for good reason. Abul Qasim was Kamran's son, elder brother to the Ibrahim whom Akbar had once wrestled for a drum. He was also a Timurid, Akbar's cousin, older than him by several years, and a perfectly likely rival for his throne – if not from ambition of his own, then as a rallying point for ambitious chieftains.

Akbar's world did not lack for ambitious chieftains. Tardi Beg himself, for example, might have crowned Abul Qasim king and declared himself his regent, leaving Akbar and Bairam stranded in Punjab. There is something